



Fear factor: “When I was very young, I was actually afraid of jumping. I was afraid of heights. I started around 10 or 11, and at first, I did not want to do the high jump simply because of that fear, says World-record holder Javier Sotomayor, seen here with his son. AP

among young children, and there were follow-ups after that.

First, you identified talent, and then you continued to nurture it. There were dedicated sports schools for teenagers where they could be closely monitored and supported. At that time, the sports infrastructure, facilities, training, support systems, and competition were all much better than they are today. We used to have coaching supervision almost every day of a child’s life.

The coaches were at a very high level. Every coach who trained a high-performance athlete had to undergo formal training; without that, they were not allowed to coach. There was a great deal of accountability. There were people above the coaches who ensured that they were actually training and continually studying their profession. This multi-level supervisory system made a big difference.

Even though Cuba was a very strong sporting nation, you were one of its biggest stars. How much

pressure was it being one of the country’s top athletes in the 1990s?

It was challenging because we were already used to seeing people win. At the 1992 Olympics alone, we had 31 medallists. So, it was never enough just to medal. If I went to a World Championships, the expectation was to win. If I did not, people would look at me strangely. The expectation was always to win gold. If I ended up with silver, it was seen as a disappointment.

You won several World and Olympic medals, but also missed out on some major competitions. You might have won another Olympic medal if not for Cuba’s boycott of the 1988 Games. Does that still bother you?

Not just the 1988 Olympics, I could also have competed at the 1984 Olympics as well [Cuba boycotted both the 1988 and 1984 Games]. But especially in 1988, I was in the best form of my life. It hurt that I could not compete. If I had gone in 1988, I would have definitely won a medal. That is why the 1992 Games were so important. The Olympics are the biggest tournament in anyone’s career, and for me, it was a personal challenge. I had to take advantage of the opportunity I had lost.

It wasn’t even that I had lost an opportunity. It was that I did not even go. The challenge I set for myself was that now that I had the opportunity, I had to seize it. I think it was one of the most important competitions of my career.

You won gold at the 1992 Olympics but faced disappointment in 1996. Could you reflect on that experience and how you came back from it?

I took part in three Olympic Games. In 1992, I won gold. In 1996, I had a knee injury, and then in 2000 I won a silver. I might have done better in 2000, but it was raining during that competition, and I never performed well in the rain. So even though I have two Olympic medals, the Olympics were actually not my best sporting moments. In 1996, my

coaches did not want me to compete because my knee injury was very bad. I jumped 2.29m, but it was not one of my better competitions.

That year, I promised myself, my family, and my coaches that I would quit the sport if I did not win a gold medal at the next year’s World Championships. I was clear that even if I won a silver or a bronze, I was going to quit. I had to win a gold.

Did you visualise yourself winning that gold medal at the 1997 World Championships?

I really started learning the art of visualisation in 1996, when I spent six months without making a single jump because of my injury. I had been doing visualisation earlier as well, but those six months were when I did it every day.

My psychologist and I mapped out the entire process precisely: the time to concentrate, the run-up, the impulse step, the final motion, the jump, the flight time. We traced all of that out with my fingers. When I jumped 2.45m, I had already visualised it in my mind. In my visualisation, I could see myself improving, going from 2.30m to 2.35m and then to 2.45m.

Would you visualise your technique during a competition, say at the top of your run-up?

At the start of my run-up, I always focused on my technique. I’d think, “What is the speed I’m going to run at?” I would think, “What’s the power I’m going to generate?” I was always visualising the jump.

These days, the high jump is extremely data-driven, with a strong focus on biomechanics. In your time, how did you prepare for such a technical event?

In my time, the only thing we had were sequential photographs of the different stages of the jump. Sometimes there were live screenings of jumps from other competitions, but in Cuba, there was not even that. We had to depend only on the photos. At a later stage, we did get some technical tools, but nothing like what is available today.